

Like all the children and grandchildren of the Mogul ruler, Khurram grew up in the palace harem. (The word *harem* comes from an Arabic word meaning “sacred” or “forbidden.”) This was where the women and children of the household stayed, apart from men. The emperor’s wives lived there, along with his mother, aunts, nieces, and young children. Female servants lived there, too. Even the harem guards were women who were trained to use a bow and arrow. The only grown man to enter was the emperor himself. He slept there. It was also where he kept his most important papers.

## The Harem

**The harem was a huge place, offering all the comfort and luxury of a royal village. Besides schools and nurseries, there were markets, laundries, kitchens, playgrounds, and baths. Entertainment included fireworks, snake charmers, dancing bears, and gazelle fights. A favorite pastime was making perfumes. The women of the harem even invested in businesses in the outside world. It was a Muslim custom for a woman to cover her face with a veil when she appeared in public.**